STATION 1 HELPER GM — THE LIBRARY (CROWN & DAGGER)

Pair: Fred Jones (Fighter) & Griffin the Invisible Man (Rogue) · **Goal:** place the 6 relics in the right statues' hands → Archive Gate opens → **Crest #1 + Evidence Card E1**. **Target:** 10–15 min. Full rules: `Stations/Station_1_Library_Crown_and_Dagger.md`.

Before the players arrive

- Six statue cards **first-name side up**: 1 Victoria · 2 Alexi · 3 Teresa · 4 Valerius · 5 Borislav · 6 Barov (on a box, he's on a tall plinth). Full titles stay face-down until the solve.
- Six relic tokens (book, scythe, dagger, spear, hammer, crown) **under a cloth "velvet runner"** on the reading table.
- Gargoyle card above the "fireplace"; Spectre standee hidden in your lap.
- **Telling Detail slips 1–6** in your hand, sorted. Envelopes 1–5 in order, Envelope 4 sealed. Phone timer.

Your special job: the Telling Detail slips

- A player inspects a statue → **Investigation DC 13** (Fred +4, Griffin +5). Success: hand over that statue's slip and tuck it under the card.
- Fail: *"Only dust and stone. Try a different approach."* They may retry next turn with a new approach (touch, smell, candle, sleeve). The clue is never locked behind one bad roll.
- **Barov needs no roll.** Any close look (Mage Hand, a climb at Athletics DC 12, or a long stare after Envelope 3) finds *nothing, not even dust* → hand over slip 6.

Station clock

Time	Do this
0:00	Read the Player Introduction aloud. Start the timer.
2:00–3:00	**Envelope 1** when they lift the runner (no roll) or inspect the table (DC 11). Not found by 3:00? The runner slides off by itself.
5:00–6:00	**Envelope 2** (hook prompt) if neither player has used their sheet yet.
8:00–9:00	**Envelope 3** when they inspect a plinth (DC 12). Not found by 9:00? A plinth plate cracks loose: hand it over.
11:00	Stuck, or right after a crown/dagger swap: **Envelope 4**, but speak only the pairs they haven't locked in.
13:00	Still stuck: read all of Envelope 4.
15:00	Lead GM's bell = hard stop. Finish fast, then **Envelope 5** and send them to the Gate.

Answer key (DM eyes only)

Statue	Detail on its slip	Relic
1 Victoria (Arch-Librarian)	Ink on fingertips	**Book**
2 Alexi (the Harvester)	Mud on boots and hem	**Scythe**
3 Teresa (the Traitor)	Crimson-stained hands	**Dagger**
4 Valerius (Admiral)	Salt, brine, barnacles	**Spear**
5 Borislav (Forge-Master)	Soot on jaw and knuckles	**Hammer**
6 Barov (the Spotless)	Nothing at all, not even dust	**Crown**

STATION 1 HELPER GM — RUNNING THE ROOM

Failure rules

- **Any wrong relic:** the statue shudders and *every* relic placed so far clatters back to the table. Sweep them all back yourself, loudly.
- **2nd wrong placement onward:** the gargoyle shrieks at everyone it can see: DC 12 Wis save or 1d6 psychic. **Griffin is invisible and never targeted.** Point that out the first time; he'll love it.
- **Crown ↔ Dagger swap** (dagger to Barov or crown to Teresa): a minor **Spectre** appears (AC 12, 14 HP, +4 to hit, 1d6 necrotic). Fred's Net Trap (DC 13 Dex) plus Griffin's Sneak Attack ends it in about a minute. This unlocks Envelope 4 early.
- **Taboo warning:** whenever someone reaches for the crown or dagger, say *"The gargoyle's eyes flare red. Are you sure?"* Say it **every time, right or wrong**, so it gives nothing away.

Nudges (questions only, never answers)

When	Say
Nobody touches the table (2–3 min)	*"That velvet runner is lumpy. Anyone curious?"*
Guessing, not looking (3–5 min)	*"These are statues of real people. What would a statue remember about the person?"*
Hooks unused (5–6 min)	Fred: *"Your sheet says you love splitting up."* Griffin: *"Barov's hands are way up there. Anything on your sheet that reaches far?"*
Five stains found (8–9 min)	*"What's strange about the sixth statue?"* / *"Have you checked the plinths?"*
Arguing over the rhyme	Give it a minute, then: *"What does a tiller do in a field?"*

Character rulings

- **Fred, "Let's Split Up!"** (station ruling): once here, Fred and his partner inspect two different statues at once, **both with Advantage**.
- **Griffin, "Mage Hand Shenanigans":** inspects Barov's plinth without climbing and can float the crown into Barov's raised hands.
- Accept Fred's **Survival** (mud) or Griffin's **Sleight of Hand** (blood under nails) as inspection rolls on the fitting statues.

Don't

- Don't name an item-statue pair or confirm a pairing before the token is placed. "Try it and see" is fine.
- Don't point at Barov or call him spotless before Envelope 3.
- Don't read the full statue titles aloud or let players see this card.
- Don't open Envelope 4 early because the table is noisy.

Reward (Envelope 5)

Flip the statue cards to show the full titles, then hand over **Crest #1** and **Evidence Card E1**. Say: *"Take these to the Grand Gate. Hurry!"*

STATION 1 — ENVELOPE LABELS (TAPE ONE TO THE FRONT OF EACH ENVELOPE)

ENVELOPE 1 · LOOK AROUND

Station 1 · Library. Open at **2–3 min**, or when they lift the runner.

ENVELOPE 2 · YOUR SHEET

Station 1 · Library. Open at **5–6 min** if hooks are unused.

ENVELOPE 3 · THE RULE

Station 1 · Library. Open on a plinth search (DC 12), or at **9:00**.

ENVELOPE 4 · SEALED: EMERGENCY

Station 1 · Library. **Helper only.** At 11:00 if stuck, or after a crown/dagger swap.

ENVELOPE 5 · REWARD

Station 1 · Library. Open on solve: **Crest #1 + Evidence Card E1**.

ENVELOPE CONTENTS (CUT OUT AND PUT INSIDE)

ENVELOPE 1 · THE READING TABLE INSCRIPTION

Hand this to the players.

> "Six walked before the master.
> The scholar reads while the tiller reaps;
> the smith burns while the sailor weeps.
> The killer's hands are scarlet stained,
> while one sits clean above the pain."

ENVELOPE 2 · HOOK PROMPT (READ ALOUD)

> Fred: "Your sheet says you love splitting up. What if you both checked different statues at the same time?"
> Griffin: "Barov's plinth is way too tall to climb easily... but something on your sheet can reach six squares."

Ruling: Let's Split Up = both inspect with Advantage this round. Mage Hand = reaches Barov.

ENVELOPE 3 · THE PLINTH PLATE

Hand this to the players.

> I. The hand is marked by what it held.
> II. The hand that never worked shall hold what was never earned.

ENVELOPE 4 · GHOST LIBRARIAN'S WHISPER (READ ALOUD)

At 11:00, speak only the pairs they haven't locked in. Full line at 13:00.

> A translucent librarian floats past, muttering: "Give the book to the ink, the scythe to the mud, the hammer to the soot, the spear to the brine, the crown to the spotless one, and the dagger to the blood!"

ENVELOPE 5 · EVIDENCE CARD E1: THE BORROWED BOOK

Goes in with Crest #1. The players carry it to the Gate.

> Tucked behind Barov's plinth: *Spooky Mechanisms for Beginners*, long overdue. The borrower's signature is smeared from right to left, the way a **left-handed** writer drags their hand through wet ink.

STATION 2 HELPER GM — THE ALCHEMIST'S LAB (TRICKSTER'S COIN)

Pair: Quasimodo (Artificer) & Shaggy Rogers (Rogue) · **Goal:** find the one **lighter** counterfeit vial among 10 using the balance scale and offer it to the jester's bowl → **Crest #2 + Evidence Card E2**. **Target:** 10–15 min. Full rules: `Stations/Station_2_Alchemist_Lab_Tricksters_Coin.md`.

Before the players arrive

- Ten **identical** vial cards in the rack, in order 1–10. Scale mat with the tilt card on **LEVEL**. Jester altar standee.
- Weighing Log and a pencil on the table. Side-effect cards (d6) in your hand. Envelope 3 (the ledger) "in the desk drawer".
- **Pick a mode with the lead GM:** □ **Fixed:** vial **#6** is the fake (simplest) · □ **Trickster's Shuffle:** keep the Suspect Tracker (boxes 1–10) on your clipboard.

Your special job: running the scale

Players put vial cards on the LEFT and RIGHT pans and say "weigh." Answer with **exactly one** of these, every time, and move the tilt card:

> "The LEFT pan rises." · "The RIGHT pan rises." · "The pans hang perfectly level."

- **Uneven counts** (e.g. 3 vs 2): the pan with **more** vials drops, so the other pan rises. This tells them nothing.
- **Even counts:** the pan holding the fake **rises**. If the fake is on neither pan → **level**.
- Always say which pan **rises**. Never switch to "drops" partway through.
- **Shuffle mode:** before answering, split the current suspects into *left / right / off the scale*. The fake hides in the **biggest** group. Announce the result that fits, then cross off everyone else.
- **Weighing cap:** 4 free weighings. On the 4th the scale **creaks**. On the 5th and later the bat **shrieks** and whoever weighed rolls a side effect. It never becomes unwinnable.

Station clock

Time	Do this
0:00	Read the Player Introduction aloud. Start the timer.
2:00–3:00	**Envelope 1** when they inspect the altar. Lore: Religion DC 10 (Quasimodo d20+4, Shaggy d20+0).
4:00–6:00	**Envelope 2** when Quasimodo sends Esmeralda. Prompt if needed: *"Quasimodo, your rat's whiskers are twitching at the rack."*
8:00–9:00	Point them at the desk: **Envelope 3** (Investigation DC 10; on a fail they still find it after a minute).
11:00	Still stuck, or after a wrong offering with a frustrated table: **Envelope 4**.
15:00	Lead GM's bell = hard stop. Finish fast, then **Envelope 5** and send them to the Gate.

Answer key (Fixed mode, fake = #6)

- 10 vials: W1 {1–5} v {6–10} → RIGHT rises · W2 {6,7} v {8,9} (10 aside) → LEFT rises · W3 6 v 7 → LEFT rises → **#6**.
- 9 vials (Esmeralda cleared #1): W1 {2,3,4} v {5,6,7} → RIGHT rises · W2 5 v 6 (7 aside) → RIGHT rises → **#6**.

STATION 2 HELPER GM — RUNNING THE ROOM

Failure rules (no damage anywhere in this room)

- **Wrong vial offered to the bowl:** angry sizzle, colourful smoke, the jester spits it back (it's now **cleared**). The person who offered it rolls d6:

d6	Side effect (lasts 5 min or until the station ends)
1	Bubble Burps: pink bubbles every time they speak
2	Helium Voice
3	Radioactive Glow (disadvantage on Stealth)
4	Sneezing Fit
5	Heavy Boots (speed −2 squares)
6	Tingling Fingers (move cards with two fingers of each hand)

Quick rulings

- **"I drink it!"** The wax seals are enchanted. Only a drop gets through: roll a side effect, no damage. The vial stays full. Not a critical mistake.
- **Hefting vials by hand:** *"They feel exactly the same."* No roll.
- **One vial against an empty pan:** the loaded pan drops. It counts as a weighing.
- **Several vials in the bowl:** spat back out. *"One offering."*
- **Clever ideas** (a homemade second scale, floating vials in water): count it as **one free weighing** and answer with the same rules.

Nudges (questions only)

When	Say
Wandering	*"The jester's bowl looks like it's waiting for something."*
Weighing 1 vs 1	*"Does the scale only take one bottle per pan?"*
After LEVEL: "that told us nothing!"	*"Did it tell you nothing, or something about the bottles left on the table?"*
Going in circles	*"Which vials can you be sure are real right now?"*
About to guess	*"Do you have a weighing left? Is guessing worth the risk?"*

Character rulings

- **Quasimodo, "Esmeralda the Rat":** clears **one** genuine vial (#1, or the lowest-numbered suspect in Shuffle mode). Use only while 3 or more suspects remain. With 2 left she just squeaks and shrugs. She can never find the fake.
- **Shaggy, "Iron Stomach":** no harm from tasting. May spend a use to end his own side effect early. Powers Envelope 4.

Don't

- Don't say a vial number as a hint, or look at the fake.
- Don't say "use 3 weighings" or "split into fives." That *is* the puzzle.
- Don't call a level result useless. Don't let a skill roll replace the scale.

Reward (Envelope 5)

Hand over **Crest #2** and **Evidence Card E2**: *"Take these to the Grand Gate!"*

STATION 2 — ENVELOPE LABELS

ENVELOPE 1 · LOOK AROUND

Station 2 · Lab. Open when they inspect the altar (**2–3 min**).

ENVELOPE 2 · YOUR SHEET

Station 2 · Lab. Open when Quasimodo uses **Esmeralda** (4–6 min).

ENVELOPE 3 · THE RULE

Station 2 · Lab. "In the desk drawer": open on a desk search (**8–9 min**).

ENVELOPE 4 · SEALED: EMERGENCY

Station 2 · Lab. **Helper only.** At 11:00 if stuck, or after a wrong offering.

ENVELOPE 5 · REWARD

Station 2 · Lab. Open on solve: **Crest #2 + Evidence Card E2**.

ENVELOPE CONTENTS

ENVELOPE 1 · THE ALTAR INSCRIPTION

Hand this to the players.

> "The Trickster mocks honest gold and heavy metal. Give to my bowl the hollow lie, the weightless fraud, the lightest craft, and the gate shall grant you passage."

Religion DC 10 (read aloud on success): *"This is an altar of the Smiling Shadow, god of forgers and frauds. It accepts only the false thing, never the true one."*

ENVELOPE 2 · ESMERALDA'S NOSE (READ ALOUD)

> Esmeralda scurries along the rack, whiskers twitching. At Vial #1 she rears back and sneezes: a hairline crack in the black wax leaks sharp quicksilver vapour. That one is the real thing. She pushes it out of line with her nose. The other seals are perfect.

Shuffle mode: swap "#1" for the lowest-numbered suspect.

ENVELOPE 3 · THE SCORCH-MARKED LEDGER

Hand this to the players.

> "Night forty. My apprentice weighs the bottles two by two and wastes the whole night. Fool. A scale answers three ways, not two: left rises, right rises, or it hangs even. When it hangs even, it speaks of the bottles left on the table. Weigh many at once. Keep some aside. And never trust a scale with uneven pans."

ENVELOPE 4 · SHAGGY'S BELCH (READ ALOUD)

> Shaggy digs a squashed triple-decker sandwich out of his pocket and wolfs it down. A second later: a concussive, echoing BURRRP. Glowing pink bubbles drift across the lab, sniff around the rack like a lost puppy, and settle, fizzing, on top of three vials.

Bubbles mark 3 current suspects, one of them the fake (both, if only 2 remain). Players still do the last weighing.

ENVELOPE 5 · EVIDENCE CARD E2: THE SINGED SLEEVE

Goes in with Crest #2.

> Under the workbench: a torn lab-coat sleeve peppered with tiny burn holes from splashed quicksilver. Whoever wore it **mixed potions every day**.

STATION 3 HELPER GM — THE CLOCKWORK OBSERVATORY (GEARS & GADGETS)

Pair: Count Dracula / Drac (Bard) & Johnny (Bard) · **Goal:** load four gears on the vault door pegs in the right order and turn the crank → the Phantom is locked away → **Crest #3 + Evidence Card E3**. **Target:** 10–15 min. Full rules: `Stations/Station_3_Clockwork_Observatory_Gears_and_Gadgets.md`.

Before the players arrive

- Vault door board (PEG 1–4, crank in the centre, small ↑ above Peg 1). Seven **identical brass** gears in a jumbled pile (pencil marks on the backs are for you).
- Clockwork Phantom standee. Plaque card (hand over when anyone looks at the door). **Star chart** (hand over when anyone touches the astrolabe or desk).
- Phone timer, plus a **second alarm for the Phantom's tick** (3:00, then every 2 minutes).

Your special job: the Phantom's tick

- **Strikes at 3:00, 5:00, 7:00, 9:00, 11:00...** and **immediately after any wrong crank.** One line of narration, one roll, back to the puzzle. No initiative.
- **Scythe Sweep:** +5 to hit, **1d6+2** slashing (Drac AC 14, Johnny AC 13). Alternate targets.
- **If a target is under 10 HP:** the Phantom knocks one placed gear back into the pile instead of dealing damage.
- **Phantom:** AC 15, 22 HP, Wis save +0. At 0 HP it bursts into gears, skips its next strike, then reassembles. It can't be destroyed; only the door locks it away.
- **The crank:** a correct set opens the door. A wrong set grinds and shrieks, gives **no hint about which gear** was wrong, and the Phantom strikes at once.

Station clock

Time	Do this
0:00	Read the Player Introduction aloud. Start both timers.
2:00–3:00	**Envelope 1** if they haven't linked the star chart to the riddle.
3:00	First Phantom strike.
5:00–6:00	**Envelope 2** when Drac uses Bat Form (or Johnny makes History DC 12).
7:00	Nudge: *"The riddle says the stars* bite*. What on this table bites?"*
8:00–9:00	**Envelope 3** when they inspect the crank, or right after a first wrong crank.
11:00	Stuck, two wrong cranks in a row, or a PC under 10 HP: **Envelope 4**.
13:00	Still stuck: the frozen Phantom points at each correct gear in turn.
15:00	Lead GM's bell = hard stop. Then **Envelope 5** and send them to the Gate.

Answer key (DM eyes only)

Peg	Teeth	Constellation
1	**4**	The Bat (under the arrow)
2	**7**	The Dragon ("great wyrm")
3	**7**	The Dragon again (the twin)
4	**3**	The Scythe ("reaper's blade")
Check	4+7+7+3 = **21**	**XXI** at the chart's centre

Decoys: the Raven (6), the Coffin (5), the Wolf (8). Any decoy breaks the 21 total.

STATION 3 HELPER GM — RUNNING THE ROOM

Character rulings (from the sheets; 3 uses each)

- **Drac, Look Into My Eyes!** (Action): the Phantom saves DC 15 Wis at +0. On a fail it **skips its next strike**. From 11:00, a success also triggers Envelope 4.
- **Drac, Bat Form** (Bonus): flies to the dome → **Envelope 2**.
- **Drac, Inspiring Bleh** (Bonus): a d8 for Johnny's next roll or save.
- **Johnny, DJ Backpack** (Reaction when the Phantom attacks him): the attack still lands, but the Phantom **skips its next strike**.
- **Johnny, Sick Beats** (once at this station): after a wrong crank, cancels that crank's strike and pops the gears back out with no penalty.
- **Johnny, Chill Vibes / Monster Mash:** a d8 for any roll, or 1d8 healing. Use freely.

Nudges (questions only)

When	Say
Only looking at gears (0–3 min)	*"What else here is the same gold as the door?"* / *"Who's checked the astrolabe?"*
Stuck on the riddle words	*"Which picture on the chart could be called that? Where's the arrow?"* / *"What does a reaper carry?"*
Drac's sheet unused (5–6 min)	*"Drac, anything on your sheet that gets you up to that ceiling?"*
Know the constellations, not what to do	*"Count something on the chart, then count something on the table."*
Full set ready	*"Before you crank it, does the riddle give you a way to check?"* / *"What's in the middle of the chart?"*

Quick rulings

- **Attacking the Phantom:** allowed and fun, but it reassembles. After a round, say: *"The pieces are already crawling back together. The* door *locks it away."*
- **Interrogating it** (Persuasion or Intimidation +7 vs DC 15): it ticks once per tooth on **one** peg. Give them Peg 1.
- **They miscount the Dragon** (6 instead of 7): don't correct them. Ask *"Does that match what the riddle says about Two and Three?"*
- **Prying the door:** it's magical and won't budge. Redirect kindly.

Don't

- Never say a tooth or star count before Envelope 4. Never say "stars equal teeth" before Envelope 3.
- Never confirm a single gear. Only a full crank gives feedback.
- Don't flip the gears over, and don't let the Phantom take more than about 30 seconds of any 2 minutes.

Reward (Envelope 5)

Hand over **Crest #3** and **Evidence Card E3**: *"Take these to the Grand Gate!"*

STATION 3 — ENVELOPE LABELS

ENVELOPE 1 · LOOK AROUND

Station 3 · Observatory. Open at **2–3 min** if they haven't linked the chart to the riddle.

ENVELOPE 2 · YOUR SHEET

Station 3 · Observatory. Open on Drac's **Bat Form** (or Johnny's History DC 12).

ENVELOPE 3 · THE RULE

Station 3 · Observatory. Open on a crank inspection or the first wrong crank (**8–9 min**).

ENVELOPE 4 · SEALED: EMERGENCY

Station 3 · Observatory. **Helper only.** At 11:00 if stuck, or after a critical mistake.

ENVELOPE 5 · REWARD

Station 3 · Observatory. Open on solve: **Crest #3 + Evidence Card E3**.

ENVELOPE CONTENTS

ENVELOPE 1 · THE PAINTED DOME (READ ALOUD)

> The clock ticks and, high above, the painted dome flickers. For a heartbeat the constellations on the ceiling glow, exactly matching the brass star chart on the desk, and a thin golden line runs from the chart's arrow down to the little arrow above Peg 1.

ENVELOPE 2 · THE GILDED STARS (READ ALOUD)

Bat Form:

> Up close, only three of the six painted constellations are inlaid with real celestial brass: the little Bat right under the arrow, the long coiled Dragon, and the curved Scythe. The Raven, the Coffin and the Wolf are just dull grey paint.

Johnny, History DC 12:

> Old Barovian stargazers called the Bat "the first wing," the Dragon "the great wyrm," and the Scythe "the reaper's blade."

ENVELOPE 3 · THE CRANK INSCRIPTION (READ ALOUD)

> Worn letters are stamped around the crank's hub: STAR FOR TOOTH · TWO AND THREE TURN AS ONE · ALL TOGETHER: THE SKY'S HEART.

Optional: after any wrong crank, Johnny may roll Performance DC 13 to hear how many *gears rang true, but not which ones.*

ENVELOPE 4 · THE HYPNOTIZED CLOCKFACE (READ ALOUD)

> The Phantom's clockface spins wildly and its ticking slows into words, the old clockmaker's rhyme: "Four in one... and three in four..." Then it freezes.

That gives Pegs 1 and 4. The twins rule plus the 21 total gives 7 + 7. At 13:00 the frozen Phantom points at each correct gear.

ENVELOPE 5 · EVIDENCE CARD E3: THE OILY FOOTPRINTS

Goes in with Crest #3.

> Gear-oil footprints lead behind the great clock: **small** boots, barely bigger than a kid's.

STATION 4 HELPER GM — THE MIMIC MENAGERIE (WANDS & KEYS)

Pair: Scooby-Doo (Barbarian) & Murray Mummy (Druid) · **Goal:** test four identical keys with four wands and lift the real one with Mage Hand → **Crest #4 + Evidence Card E4**. **Target:** 10–15 min. Full rules: `Stations/Station_4_Mimic_Menagerie_Wands_and_Keys.md`.

Before the players arrive

- Four **identical** alcove cards, Alcove I–IV. Four wand cards; a **purple bead on Poison** and a **green bead on Acid** (one charge each).
- Reveal tiles (Illusion Dispelled, Mimic, Disarmed Construct) face down in your box. The Menagerie plaque (Envelope 3) face down under the wand rack.
- Shuffle Tracker on your clipboard with a **paperclip on the starting layout**. **A real snack for Scooby; check allergies.** Phone timer.

Your special job: the shuffle and the wands

- **Collect the bead before narrating.** The moment a player fires Poison or Acid, hold out your hand for the bead.
- **Read the matrix wording exactly.** Identical outcomes get identical words, so plain results are clues too.
- **A wrong key lifted** (by hand, mage hand, whip, or a thrown object) triggers that alcove, then **reset**: read the reset line, move the paperclip **A → B → C → D → A**, clear all reveal tiles, return both beads.

> Reset line: "With a grinding roar, the four arches spin like a roulette wheel and lock back into place. Whatever you learned, it's scrambled now. Two fresh gems click into the wand cradles."

Layout	Alcove I	Alcove II	Alcove III	Alcove IV
A	Illusion	Mimic	Construct	**Real**
B	**Real**	Construct	Illusion	Mimic
C	Construct	**Real**	Mimic	Illusion
D	Mimic	Illusion	**Real**	Construct

Wand reaction matrix (say these words exactly)

Content	Bright Light	Poison (1 charge)	Acid (1 charge)	Mage Hand (lifts)
Illusion	Shadow stays frozen. **Reveal.**	"The mist drifts straight *through* the key." **Reveal.**	"The acid passes through and hisses on the wall behind." **Reveal.**	Gong, cold vapour. **Reset.**
Mimic	"Its shadow swings with the beam."	Gags and slumps into a grey blob. **Reveal.**	"The acid splashes over the key and hisses on the pedestal. The key looks unharmed."	Bites, lunges. **Reset.**
Construct	"Its shadow swings with the beam."	"The mist beads on the metal and drifts away."	Casing melts, fuse dies. **Reveal (disarmed).**	Explodes. **Reset.**
Real key	"Its shadow swings with the beam."	"The mist beads on the metal and drifts away."	"The acid splashes over the key and hisses on the pedestal. The key looks unharmed."	**Success!**

STATION 4 HELPER GM — RUNNING THE ROOM

Station clock

Time	Do this
0:00	Read the Player Introduction aloud. Start the timer.
2:00–3:00	**Envelope 1** when they look around, or someone reaches for a key with no plan.
5:00–6:00	**Envelope 2**: toss Scooby a real snack if he hasn't used Snack Surge.
8:00–9:00	**Envelope 3** on a wand-rack search (Investigation DC 10), or reveal it at 9:00.
11:00	Stuck, or a reset after 10:00: **Envelope 4**.
13:00	Not solved: the real key starts to glow faintly.
15:00	Lead GM's bell = hard stop. Then **Envelope 5** and send them to the Gate.

Hazards (scaled for teens)

- **Mimic** (AC 12, 15 HP): one bite at whoever disturbed it, +5 to hit, **1d8+2 piercing + 2 acid** (it crunches a mage hand instead and gets no bite). Then Murray's Shuffle and Scooby's bites finish it, then **reset**.
- **Construct:** everyone within 30 ft makes a **DC 12 Dex save, 2d4** damage, half on a save. Then **reset**.
- **Illusion:** a gong, no damage. **Reset.**

Character rulings

- **Scooby, Scooby Snack Surge** (needs a real snack): +14 Perception vs DC 12. Scooby asks **one** question: *"alive?"* (finds the mimic) or *"fake?"* (finds the illusion). After a reset, only DC 15 without a surge, unless you give a mercy snack.
- **Murray, Sandstorm Shuffle** (Action): automatically restrains the mimic for 2 rounds.
- **Murray, Nature DC 10:** *"Mimics digest with acid. Acid won't bother one, but poison makes them gag."*
- **Murray, Bandage Whip** (reach 2 squares): lifting a key counts as Mage Hand. **Tapping a pedestal** (not the key) is safe and gives that alcove's Envelope 4 sound.

Nudges (questions only)

- About to grab a key: *"Does anything here tell you what happened to the last people?"*
- Zapping at random: *"What question does each wand answer?"*
- Forgot the charges: *"Anything printed on the wand cards you haven't used?"*
- Ignoring Scooby: *"Scooby, your stomach just growled."*
- Two keys left, no charges: *"Anything either of you can do that isn't a wand?"*

Don't

- Don't hint at any alcove, and keep a straight face when they point at the real one.
- Don't put a reveal tile or the mimic standee out until it's earned.
- Don't call them "the mimic wand" or "the bomb wand"; use the wand names.

Reward (Envelope 5)

Hand over **Crest #4** and **Evidence Card E4**: *"Take these to the Grand Gate!"*

STATION 4 — ENVELOPE LABELS

ENVELOPE 1 · LOOK AROUND

Station 4 · Menagerie. Open at **2–3 min**, or when someone reaches for a key with no plan.

ENVELOPE 2 · YOUR SHEET

Station 4 · Menagerie. Open on **Scooby Snack Surge** (5–6 min). Bring a real snack!

ENVELOPE 3 · THE RULE

Station 4 · Menagerie. Open on a wand-rack search (DC 10), or at **9:00**.

ENVELOPE 4 · SEALED: EMERGENCY

Station 4 · Menagerie. **Helper only.** At 11:00 if stuck, or after a reset past 10:00.

ENVELOPE 5 · REWARD

Station 4 · Menagerie. Open on solve: **Crest #4 + Evidence Card E4**.

ENVELOPE CONTENTS

ENVELOPE 1 · THE SCORCHED FLOOR (READ ALOUD)

> Just past the line of brass studs, the floor is scorched in a black fan shape: deep tooth gouges in the flagstones and a dried, sticky puddle. Nothing like that is on your side of the line. The wand cradles are worn smooth. Two of them have a single socket where a charge-gem sits.

ENVELOPE 2 · SCOOBY SNACK SURGE (READ ALOUD)

Fill in the alcove from the current layout.

> "alive?" → Scooby's snout twitches into overdrive. Alcove ___ smells like a wet swamp monster that just ate a meatloaf. Something in there is breathing.
> "fake?" → Alcove ___ smells of... nothing at all. Not metal, not dust. It's like the key isn't there.

ENVELOPE 3 · THE MENAGERIE PLAQUE

Hand this to the players.

> Four keys wait, and three are lies.
> What casts no true shadow, the sun will expose;
> What lives will choke where the venom blows;
> What ticks, the acid melts from within;
> One breath, one drop: spend them, then win.
> Touch none with your hand. Let the ghost hand begin.

ENVELOPE 4 · MURRAY'S BANDAGE TAP (READ ALOUD)

Prompt: "Murray, your Bandage Whip reaches 2 squares. Want to tap the pedestals, without touching the keys?" Fill in from the current layout.

> Tap... Alcove ___ lets out an irritated, wet snore. Tap... Alcove ___ gives a faint clockwork tick-tick-tick. Tap... the whip passes straight through the key in Alcove ___. Tap... Alcove ___ rings like a pure, hollow brass bell.

ENVELOPE 5 · EVIDENCE CARD E4: THE MIMIC'S SNACK

Goes in with Crest #4.

> Stuck between the mimic's needle teeth: a tuft of hair stained bright **purple**.

STATION 5 HELPER GM — THE COLLAPSING ARMORY (TABOO WORD)

Pair: Frankenstein / Frank (Barbarian) & Wayne Werewolf (Barbarian) · **Goal:** stop the ceiling, decode the door password, retrieve the crest from the grate, without saying the forbidden word → **Crest #5 + Evidence Card E5**. **Target:** 10–15 min. Full rules: `Stations/Station_5_Collapsing_Armory_Corridor_of_the_Taboo_Word.md`.

Before the players arrive

- Corridor mat (Sheets A + B taped together). Rack tags in their slots: **A-top-1 Spear · A-bottom-1 Mace · A-top-2 Net · A-bottom-2 Axe · B-top-1 Glaive · B-bottom-1 Rapier · B-top-2 Halberd · B-bottom-2 Executioner's Blade**.
- Five ceiling word cards face up, scrambled. Tracker slider at **15 FT**. Archway plaque ready to hand over. Blueprint (give it when they examine the grate).
- Bell (or squeaky toy), 1-minute sand timer by the door, penalty cards 1–8 face down, a d8, the pups token. Phone stopwatch.

Your special job: the word, the bell and the ceiling

- **The forbidden word is TRAP. You never say it**, not even in rules talk. Call it "the word" and point at the plaque.
- **Counts:** trap, traps, trapped, trapdoor, booby-trap, mousetrap, "it's a trap!", spelling it aloud, reading it off a sheet. **Doesn't count:** strap, trapeze, other languages (piège, Falle, trampa), writing, miming, pointing.
- **Each slip:** ring the bell → roll d8 and show that penalty card → flip the sand timer (the door is **locked 1 minute**, and passwords during a lockout are ignored). The ceiling keeps moving.
- **Watch Frank's sheet:** the *Massive Shoulders* text contains the word. If Frank's player reads it aloud word for word, ring the bell with a big grin.
- **The ceiling:** every real minute, slide the tracker down **1 ft** and say it aloud (*"Thirteen feet. Grrrind."*). **CROUCH at 5 ft** (half speed). **CRUSH at 0 ft** (minute 15): the floor tilts and dumps everyone out the door (2d6 each, nobody drops below 1 HP). It **stops** the moment Frank braces.

Station clock

Time	Do this
0:00	Hand over the plaque, explain the rule once (Player Introduction), start the stopwatch.
2:30	**Envelope 1** if they haven't connected the ceiling words to the racks.
5:00–6:00	**Envelope 2** when Frank goes toward the ceiling (DC 11 Perception or Investigation, or automatic if he touches it).
8:00–9:00	**Envelope 3** once they've matched 3 or more cards, or when they inspect the door.
11:00	Stuck: **Envelope 4**, the variant that fits.
15:00	Lead GM's bell = hard stop. Then **Envelope 5** and send them to the Gate.

STATION 5 HELPER GM — RUNNING THE ROOM

Answer key (DM eyes only)

- **Ceiling:** Frank stands under the gargoyle boss and uses **Massive Shoulders** (Action, automatic success). While braced he can't move, but his player can still talk and sort cards.
- **Password:** match the 5 ceiling words to rack tags (by eye, or Investigation DC 12 per card). Lit racks: **S**pear, **N**et, **A**xe, **R**apier, **E**xecutioner's Blade. First letters from entrance to door = **SNARE**. The plaque already lists "snares" as an allowed word. Wrong passwords just make the stone mouth cough dust.
- **Decoy:** the Sylvan Halberd tag looks like the Elvish Rapier card. Elvish loops are **closed**; Sylvan loops are **open**.
- **The crest is in the RIGHT pipe.** Wayne's Wolf Senses: Perception DC 10 with advantage hears it. Swarm of Pups fetches it, and **one use lasts the whole station**. Sent without listening, roll 1d3: 1 left (broken sword hilt), 2 centre (soggy boot), 3 right (crest!). Each wrong pipe costs about a minute.
- **Exit:** Frank lets go and dives for the door: DC 10 Dex or 1d6 piercing. He always makes it.

d8 penalty table (scaled)

d8	Effect
1	Wall Arrows: +5 to hit, 1d6+2 piercing
2	Constricting Vines: DC 13 Str or Restrained (Action + DC 13 Athletics to break free; Frank has advantage)
3	Heat Metal: drop the item or take 1d8 fire
4	Blinding Flash: DC 13 Cha or blinded 1 round
5	Flame Jet: DC 13 Dex, 2d6 fire, half on a save (Frank yelps; he's scared of fire)
6	Grease Siphon: DC 13 Dex or prone
7	Pendulum Blade: +5 to hit, 1d8+3 slashing
8	Ceiling Surge: the ceiling drops 2 ft at once (if Frank is braced: DC 13 Athletics with advantage, or the drop happens anyway and he takes 1d6)

Nudges (questions only)

- *"The words on the ceiling are glowing. How many racks are there? How many words?"*
- *"Do any of those squiggles look like anything else in the room?"*
- *"Who in the party has the loudest muscles for that ceiling?"* (point at Frank, not at the ability)
- *"You've got five weapons. What's the door waiting for?"* / *"Read your plaque again. What are you allowed to talk about?"*
- At the grate: *"Your hands won't fit. Who's small enough?"* / *"Wayne, which way do your nose and ears point?"*

Derails

- **Saying it on purpose for laughs:** it still counts. On a third deliberate slip within a minute, it's automatically **result 8**: "the room gets bored of the joke."
- **Arguing over variants:** one sentence from the table above, then move on.
- **Clever workarounds** (other languages, miming, a hand over a mouth): allowed. Praise them!
- **Prying the grate or door:** fused to the bedrock. Give them a fair roll, but it doesn't budge.

Don't

- Never say the word, "SNARE", "first letters" or "in order" before Envelope 3. Never point at a rack.
- Never name *Massive Shoulders* or *Swarm of Pups*; point at the sheets instead. Nobody goes to 0 HP here.

STATION 5 — ENVELOPE LABELS

ENVELOPE 1 · LOOK AROUND

Station 5 · Armory. Open at **2:30** if they haven't linked the words to the racks.

ENVELOPE 2 · YOUR SHEET

Station 5 · Armory. Open when Frank goes toward the ceiling (**5–6 min**).

ENVELOPE 3 · THE RULE

Station 5 · Armory. Open after 3+ matches, or a door inspection (**8–9 min**).

ENVELOPE 4 · SEALED: EMERGENCY

Station 5 · Armory. **Helper only.** At 11:00 if stuck, or after a critical mistake.

ENVELOPE 5 · REWARD

Station 5 · Armory. Open on solve: **Crest #5 + Evidence Card E5**.

ENVELOPE CONTENTS

ENVELOPE 1 · THE PULSING WORDS (READ ALOUD)

> The ceiling grinds down another notch. The five glowing words on its underside pulse all at once, and each time they flash, a soft brass "ping" answers from somewhere along the weapon racks. Not all of the racks. Some of them.

ENVELOPE 2 · THE KEYSTONE BOSS (READ ALOUD)

> Frank notices the spiked ceiling isn't one solid slab. All eight piston shafts meet at a single stone gargoyle boss right above the floor grate. Something big enough could hold that one point and stop the whole thing. Frank's shoulders twitch.

ENVELOPE 3 · THE DOOR'S MOUTH (READ ALOUD)

> Five empty sockets above the blast door light up, and the carved stone mouth whispers: "From the first steel to the last, take the head of every lit blade, and speak it plain."

ENVELOPE 4 · BILGE SURGE (READ ALOUD)

A · stuck on the password:

> The ceiling's weight cracks the five glowing words loose. They drop with a clang, each one landing on its own rack. The lit racks are now obvious.

B · stuck on the crest:

> A surge of drain water floods the sump! Wayne hears the brass chain sliding down the RIGHT pipe toward a bottomless drop. If anything small is going down there, it has to be NOW!

ENVELOPE 5 · EVIDENCE CARD E5: THE STINKY GLOVE

Goes in with Crest #5.

> The pups drag up a glove along with the crest. It reeks of rotten eggs: **sulfur**.